Affairs of the Estate

certifiableGrimalkin

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Prologue

The figure’s blade was splattered with oily, curdled blood, that ran down it’s length and dripped in chunks. It was the early afternoon, and the sun was beaming down across the fields of barley.

Across from the figure, in a heap on the ground, lay a mangled, cut up corpse, a desiccated man in his late twenties, of a sturdy build. His clothes, now tatters with spots of grime, ground and guts, showed him to be a peasant.

The corpse twitched, and the figure noted the glow, as the cracking of joining and setting bones began, the corpse rising onto his feet. More than enough time.

From underneath the white cloak, the figure retrieved an ornate, if worn book, and fingered through the pages, finding the right one. As the corpse started shambling, then walking towards the figure.

"Do your thing," muttered the figure.

"No fun," answered the page, playfully.

There was a moment of silence, that boomed out from the book, quietening the sway of growing grains, chirping of bugs and steps of humanoids. This sphere of silence was then filled by tones and sounds, purposefully placed, working their way through an intricate symphony of noise. At times it seemed like speech or song, at times like the memory of a meal, at times like the soundscape of a graveyard late at night.

The walking corpse started burning in a bright flame, from the places where just before the figure had cut it into pieces. The flame spread across the silently screaming man, devouring muscle, cartilage and bone with a uniform hunger. Soon there was nothing left of that man, but a heap of clean ash, that the wind started carrying out over the fields.

The figure closed the book, hid it back in a spot under their cloak, then wiped the blade on the field beside, and continued down the road, towards the village, towards the estate.

Encounter

The cloaked figure encountered two more risen dead, on the way through the fields. Both were taken care of with not much effort. But after that, everything got quiet. Only the wind brushing the blades of the field and the buzzing and chirping of bugs accompanied them through.

The silence became more deafening, going through the town. The occasional creaking of the wood under the gusts of wind, or shuddering of the windows gave the empty streets a familiar unlife. The figure's instincts were all telling them to find a better vantage point. That this was a trap. That something was very wrong. But sneaking through the fields would have been even more dangerous. This was the safest option, they convinced themself, proceeding slowly and cautiously, eyeing every door and window, every shadow and movement.

Nothing happening set all their nerves even more on edge, looking to the mansion on the nearby hill, to which the road out of the village was leading. The sun has by this point lowered, and from this viewpoint, it had hid behind the main building of the mansion, lending it's outline and some of its windows and otherworldly light. Contrasted with the long shadows and darkness spreading from the mansion, it looked both watchful, and taking hold of everything around.

As the figure stepped through the outside gates of the estate, the rows of lanterns lining the path lit up, in a warm, red glow, as if eyes of a beast, slowly waking. The light invited up, towards the main doors, as the last of the daylight faded, as if devoured by the dark building.

The path seemed perilous, but wading through the darkness sounded delirious. Watched by the lanterns, and lit up in a soft red, the figure ascended the hill, furtively and listening for even the smallest sound of anything out of place. The blade of their scythe gleamed as if with blood, cutting through a speck of darkness at a time, with the help of the patient watchers.

The dark, heavy doors of the mansion started crying and straining in pain, startling the figure. With considerable effort of unseen hands, they heaved open, revealing a blackness within.

Red glimmers sparkled across some shapes and forms of furniture and knick-knacks. And with a short snapping sound, there appeared a lit chandelier out of the darkness, in the middle of the room, bathing the rest in a welcoming, yellow light.

The cloaked figure entered, shifting their eyes over the shimmering, red-tainted shadows made by the candlelight.

Distinct, clacking steps started coming from the faraway stairs, winding in the back of this hall. Against the darkness, and the silence around, they reverberated through the room and held attention firmly. The figure noted a form, once it arrived at the top of the last set of steps, and then perceived the details, once the form had stopped in the middle of them, at the edge of the light.

Most of the form was a delicate, translucent golden dress, flowing as much on her as floating and following behind her. Beneath it, the forms were right, but the shapes were wrong. The dress acted as if the woman filled it perfectly, despite the fact there was naught but bone on one of her legs, her ribs were showing with only one of her breasts perked, and the left side of her face missing an eyes and most of its skin. Even the rest of the flesh looked dry and stretched. She did not let that bother her though. The most pertinent detail of her appearance, was her mildly displeased glare, which could have supplied a good armoury for a long time, and was directly aimed at the center of the white cloak’s hood.

"Tsk!" she said, and scanned the whole figure, from head to toe.

"Sit, dear." A chair emerged from the shadows behind the figure.

After a swift moment of shock, the figure composed themself. This was the woman of the house. The source of all the undeath. Under their cloak, they let their fingers slide along the spine of the book. It shivered gently, calming them. With a quick step, the figure sprinted towards the stairs, readying a swing of their scythe. They leapt into the air, and spun around, cleanly passing the blade through the lady’s midsection. They pulled the book out, before the bottom half of the golden dress landed gently on the floor.

"Go ahead," they mouthed to the open page, as the sphere of silence already started expanding. They turned around, to face the lady, as the cacophony of noises and feelings filled the space. The lady’s entire midriff started glowing a painful light. Flames spurted out, singing the frayed edges of the cut dress.

Then she turned around. Stepping slowly, casually, she put her hand on where her hip would have been, and her gaze on the cloaked figure. The bright fire burning in her was shining

through her piercing eyes, amplified by the disgruntled displeasure visible on her half-lip. She sighed. The darkness around them grew denser.

The figure jumped back, and paged to another section. They raised the book up, and started singing a distorted melody, or maybe a hymn in a language no one wanted to know. A violent screaming arose from the book itself.

"-aargh! Fucking finally! Now you let me free!"

The book began to glow, the light expanding to the range of the silence from before, passing through everything in its way. From the bright membrane, shapes began to emerge. Eyes, wings, teeth, beaks. A long cylinder started growing behind the lady, ballooning out into a fowl-head, complete with six sets of eyes, and a beak filled to the brim with razor sharp teeth. With a sharp movement, the mouth shot down over the lady, and enveloped her. A white flame erupted from where she had stood. The fowl-head swallowed.

Then the white membrane forming the beast started dimming and misshaping. A pressure was growing from the outside, pressing into the light. There was a ripping sound, as streams of darkness grew through, vining up the beast's throat. The darkness gripped tight. The throat gave way, with a airy squelch. The lady, cocooned in darkness, floated gently onto the floor. None of her dress was left. Her hat was in tatters. Her undergarments were in scraps. The bright light faded, leaving only the candelabra's flickering warmth.

She stepped up to the gasping figure, and put a finger out to their forehead.

"Sit," she said, as the figure's legs gave out under them, landing them on a chair, whose presence they were not going to doubt for the moment. Their scythe clattered down behind them.

She circled around them, and stepped with a heel onto the book.

"You come into my land. Destroy my bodies. Scare my people. Free these obscenities in my home. And destroy my dress. What will I do with you, Sugar?"

She tilts down, holding their face up by their chin, and looking them into their eyes. Then ponders a bit, and picks up the book.

"It'll have to wait. You left me in dire need of freshening up, Darling." The lady moved away, up the stairs, into the darkness, leaving the figure alone on the stairs.

They struggled for a little, against the chair. Thick shadowy tendrils were making it hard to move, or move the chair at all.

They bode.